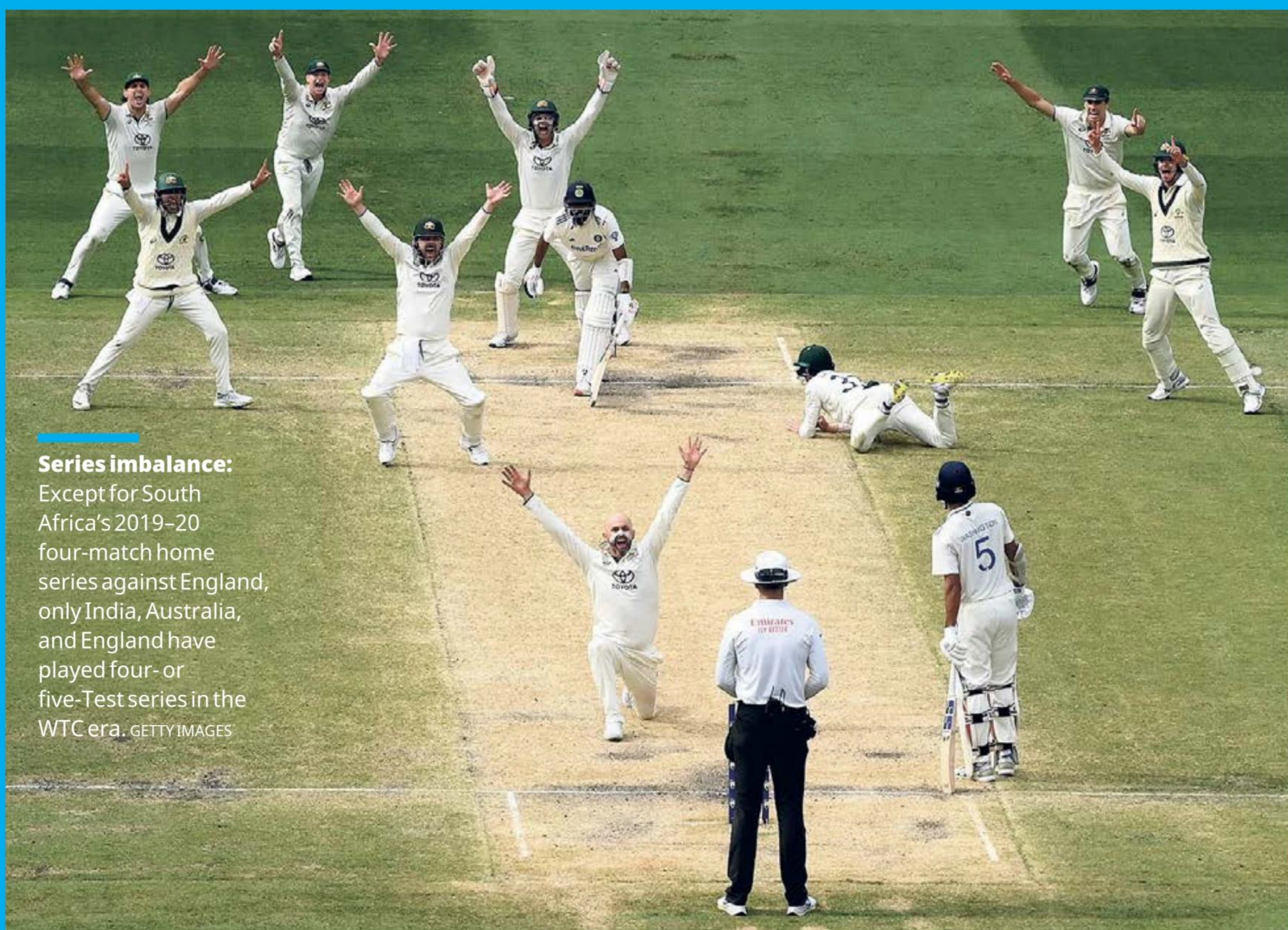




Series imbalance:

Except for South Africa's 2019–20 four-match home series against England, only India, Australia, and England have played four- or five-Test series in the WTC era. GETTY IMAGES

Sri Lanka and West Indies have also largely featured in two-match contests since 2019.

Moreover, barring South Africa's four-match series against England at home in 2019–20, India, Australia and England are the only teams to have featured in series lasting four or five Tests in the WTC era.

While the length of a series is agreed upon by the cricketing boards of the participating teams, an intervention by the ICC with regards to making a three-match Test series

the bare minimum can help level the playing field.

The difference in the quality of opposition that teams face is also an aspect of the WTC that inhibits a fair assessment. The criticism of South Africa's seemingly easier path to the final involves the fact that it neither faced Australia nor England. Meanwhile, largely driven by market forces, India has played both Australia and England in each of the three WTC cycles.

Extending the WTC cycle from six

series per team to eight and ensuring that all nine participants get a taste of each other is a straightforward solution.

The ICC's very own team rankings are also an indictment of the WTC standings. One would assume the rankings, which consider a minimum of 36 months and take into account the strength of the opposition, should largely be reflective of the points table of a tournament that runs over two years. However, in the rankings update issued in May, England was placed second, while in the WTC standings it sits a lowly fifth, largely owing to slow over-rate penalties.

While the current structure of the WTC leaves much to be desired, the competition has kept the flame of Tests flickering amidst the gusts of T20 cricket.

As murmurs of a two-tier system prioritising the Big Three — Australia, England, and India — do the rounds, the custodians of cricket would do well to not snuff it out for the rest.

Team-wise distribution of matches in WTC era (2019-2025)

Team	Matches	Won	Lost	Drawn
England	73	35	28	10
India	56	31	19	6
Australia	53	33	11	9
New Zealand	45	22	18	5
Pakistan	42	15	20	7
Sri Lanka	42	16	20	6
West Indies	42	12	23	7
South Africa	40	21	17	2
Bangladesh	38	10	26	2